the same year he left America for Europe with no predetermined date of return. Robeson's career initially rebounded through appearances in Asia and Europe. In 1960 he was honored in Cold War Berlin by East Germany, received an honorary degree of doctor of philosophy from Humboldt University, and was awarded the German Peace Medal, the Großer Stern der Völkerfreundschaft (Great Star of Friendship among the Peoples]), bestowed by East German leader Walter Ulbricht.

Robeson's next trip to East Germany, after the Wall's construction, offered less of a public spectacle than a secluded rescue mission. When Robeson had returned to the international stage a few years earlier, lingering health issues and deep anxiety further plagued him. In 1961, after a suspicious turn of events in Moscow following a performance for Africa Freedom Day, members of his family suspected that covert operatives from either the CIA or the Soviet Union poisoned the performer. Robeson was subsequently institutionalized in a mental hospital in London.[30] He then disappeared from public life and was treated with episodic electric shock treatments and heavy sedatives for nearly two years, during which he remained almost entirely catatonic. After prolonged concerns about her husband's safety and distrust of his convalescence, his wife, Eslanda Robeson, furtively coordinated a change of course in his treatments.

At daybreak on a Sunday morning in late August 1963, with the help of a Polish ambassador and at the invitation of the GDR-based German Peace Council, the Robesons flew to East Berlin for alternative health treatment. Dramatic reports of this "escape" from London to East Berlin rippled across the world press. Headlines such as "Robeson Flown to East Berlin: Wife Boasts of 'Cloak and Dagger' Work" and "Departure Kept Secret" suggested an espionage angle to the story. Eslanda issued a three-part explanation in the *Baltimore Afro American* weeks later in which she detailed the circumstances of the couple's relocation to East Berlin, highlighting the circuits of alternative diplomacy that she tapped for the urgent trip. Although she made a case for the furtive nature of the transfer (to avoid a persistent press and give her husband a chance to fully recover with new treatment), the headlines adjoining her stories further sensationalized the accounts: "Why He 'Sneaked' to East Germany" and "'Escape' Reads Like Movie Thriller."[31] Despite the nuances and details of her first-person account, the press's framing of the story continued to sensationalize Robeson's travel to the divided city.